How to Translate a Joke and Mama

By Emtithal (Emi) Mahmoud

How to Translate a Joke (Pg 37)

A man walks into the market,

looking for a date.

He asks the village playboy for help.

The village playboy says:

"Watch and learn."

He walks up to a girl selling honey and says:

"Do you have any honey, honey?"

She swoons. Gives him honey and a kiss.

He walks up to a woman selling flowers:

"Do you have any flowers, you rose?"

She melts. Gives him flowers and a kiss.

He walks to a third woman.

"Do you have any sugar, sugar?"

She practically dies. Gives him sugar and kisses him twice.

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The playboy comes back.

"Your turn, stud."

The man apprehensively walks up to a woman selling dairy and says: "Do you have any milk, cow?"

NATIONAL USE

INTRODUCTION

Events in 2021 and 2022 have conspired to crush the rights and dignity of millions of women and girls world-wide:

Recently, a man in Pakistan set his house on fire, killing his daughters and grandchildren to protect his "honor" from the social repercussions of an inappropriate marriage. Female judges and lawyers, now obsolete entities in the Taliban regime of Afghanistan, are hiding in fear of torture and death and females can no longer attend educational facilities. In Iran, the violent arrest of a woman was captured on video, depicting her capture with a dog-catcher's pole, before being thrown in the back of a van for her inappropriate display of a hijab. She later died in the custody of the "morality police." And in the US, women are losing the right of choice as Roe v Wade is overturned.

In the words of the poet, "My greatest dream for the future is that one day my poetry will become a marker of how things used to be --"a relic of history."

Sudanese born, Emi Mahmoud cries out for the oppression all women face in How to Translate a Joke and Mama.

Realize that humor transcends all boundaries.
That laughter is a language that knows no borders.
That this joke that I learned in Arabic,
makes perfect sense in English and French
and in any other language.
Realize that we call women cows in every language.

Realize that humor leaves little room for questions,
and even less room for victims,
and even less room for apologies.

Realize that in one version of this joke,
the man is looking to pick up girls.
In another he's looking for a wife.
In a third, he's looking for an answer.
And maybe the cow slaps him.
Or the cow asks him to leave and he tries again.
Or she walks faster, clutches her purse.
Or maybe she threatens him and is jailed for treason.
Or maybe the cow sues him.
And the case is dismissed.
Or they settle . . . down.

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We are willing to say offensive more than we say
dangerous.
As if harm isn't transitive.
As if it isn't something you do to another person.

We like to pretend that I am not as uncomfortable alone
on the streets of New York as I am on the streets of Nepal.
That a stroll in Philly or Indiana or Minnesota,
doesn't bring as many stares as in India or Sudan or Egypt.
That violence is a third-world-problem.
That it isn't here. Hiding. In a conversation.
Or in a bouquet. Or a market.
That not being alone makes a difference.
If they don't get the joke, say it again.
Smile more this time. Repeat the punchline.
Pause for dramatic effect. Use jazz-hands if you have to.
Laugh.

In another version,
that man walks into a market looking for a date,
and leaves with an unwilling woman.
A bounty. That in my language I am a sweet.

And if not that, a decoration.
A flower. A gift.

He walks up to the girl selling honey.
She gives him her eyes. Her arms. Her silence.

He walks up to the girl selling sugar.
She practically *dies.*

He walks up to the girl selling flowers.
Calls her a rose. Strips all her thorns.
Sticks her in a bouquet.
She fights. He breaks her.
Calls her a dead thing.
She melts. Is trampled in the market.
There are four women in the joke.
None of them speak.

Realize that humor transcends all realities.
That laughter is a language that knows no borders.
That this joke I heard in Arabic,
hurts just as much in English and French
and in any other dialect.

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Mama (Pg 108)

I was walking down the street when a man stopped me and said,
Hey yo sistah, you from the motherland?
Because my skin is a shade too deep not to have come from foreign soil
Because this garment on my head screams Africa
Because my body is a beacon calling everybody to come flock to the motherland

I said, ***I'm Sudanese, why?***
He says, ***'cause you got a little bit of flavor in you,***
I'm just admiring what your mama gave you

Let me tell you something about my mama
She can reduce a man to tattered flesh without so much as blinking
Her words fester beneath your skin and the whole time,
You won't be able to stop cradling her eyes.
My mama is a woman, flawless and formidable in the same step.
Woman walks into a warzone and has warriors cowering at

her feet
My mama carries all of us in her body,
on her face, in her blood and
Blood is no good once you let it loose
So she always holds us close.

When I was 7, she cradled bullets in the billows of her robes.
That same night, she taught me how to get gunpowder out of cotton with a bar of soap.
Years later when the soldiers held her at gunpoint and asked her who she was
She said, ***I am a daughter of Adam, I am a woman, who the hell are you?***

The last time we went home, we watched our village burn,
Soldiers pouring blood from civilian skulls
As if they too could turn water into wine.
They stole the ground beneath our feet.

The woman who raised me
turned and said, ***don't be scared***
I'm your mother, I'm here, I won't let them through.

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My mama gave me conviction.
Women like her
Inherit tired eyes,
Bruised wrists and titanium plated spines.
The daughters of widows wearing the wings of amputees
Carry countries between their shoulder blades.

[So. . .] Don't talk about the motherland unless you know that being from Africa
means waking up an afterthought in this country.
Don't talk about my flavor unless you know that
My flavor is insurrection, it is rebellion, resistance my flavor is mutiny
It is burden, it is grit and it is compromise
And you don't know compromise until you've rebuilt your home for the third time
Without bricks, without mortar, without any other option

I turned to the man and said,
My mother and I can't walk the streets alone

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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